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California Congress approves $2.5 billion to respond to Los Angeles wildfires

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California will allocate $2.5 billion to help the Los Angeles metropolitan area recover from the recent deadly wildfires with an aid package signed into law Thursday by Democratic Gov. Gavin Newsom.

Newsom signed the bills into law after the state Congress passed them with bipartisan support hours earlier in the day. The measures include $2.5 billion for the state's emergency disaster response efforts, such as evacuations, sheltering survivors and disposing of household hazardous waste. Lawmakers also approved $4 million for local governments to expedite approvals for home rebuilding, and $1 million to support school districts and help them rebuild facilities.

"This is about instilling a sense of hope," Newsom told a news conference in Pasadena, a city recovering from one of the fires that raged this month.

The aid was approved a day before President Donald Trump is scheduled to visit California to survey the damage caused by the fires. He has hinted that any federal aid to deal with wildfires should come with strings attached, although congressional Republicans representing the state have rejected that idea. Former President Joe Biden already approved some disaster aid for the region a few weeks ago.

Newsom called lawmakers into a special session in November in order to prepare for legal showdowns against the Trump administration. But after major fires broke out around Los Angeles, the governor shifted his position and focused on prioritizing funds to support people affected by fires. He broadened the focus of the special session to approve recovery funding, under pressure from Republican state lawmakers, who said the focus on Trump was misguided at a time when the state was dealing with disaster.

Republican state Sen. Kelly Seyarto criticized Newsom for not issuing fire relief funding on his own, but Seyarto ultimately supported the proposals.

He said that, going forward, Democrats should do a better job of working with Republicans to craft legislation for fire response and prevention funding.

"We need a plan from all of us to make sure this doesn't happen again," he commented.

The state Senate also approved $25 million Thursday to defend the state against legal challenges from the federal government, along with another $25 million whose use would go in part to legal groups defending immigrants against possible deportations and other threats. The votes were cast largely along party lines. The state Assembly is still required to approve the proposals before they can reach Newsom's desk.

The largest of the recent fires in Southern California began Jan. 7, sweeping through the Pacific Palisades neighborhood of Los Angeles and leaving 11 dead. The Eaton Fire, which broke out the same day near Altadena, has killed 17 people.

Now the region is also battling the Hughes Fire, which started Wednesday north of Los Angeles, spread over 15 square miles (39 square kilometers) and forced evacuation orders or alerts for more than 50,000 people.

Acting state Senate President Mike McGuire, a Democrat who represents the North Coast, said the fires have been "nothing short of devastating."

"But we promise you we're with you, and we're going to get through this," he declared before Newsom signed the relief bill into law.

Newsom's administration indicated that the state expects the federal government to reimburse it for disaster relief funding.

The governor also announced Thursday a commitment by 270 state banks, credit unions and lenders to provide mortgage relief to homeowners affected by the fires in Los Angeles and Ventura counties.

Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, an Encino Democrat and chairman of the House special session budget committee, indicated that his family was ordered to evacuate for six days while firefighters battled the Palisades Fire.

The funding Congress approved Thursday is "the first of many steps" lawmakers will take to support wildfire survivors and protect communities from the threat of future fires, he said.

"No community is immune from these wildfires," Gabriel declared. "That's part of what the tragedy in Los Angeles showed us."

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